During his third MLA term (2019-2024), Majhi stood out as a vocal chief whip of the Opposition, using his oratory to take the fight to the ruling camp, particularly when leader of the Opposition Pradipta Kumar Naik was down with Covid.

While Majhi will be its tribal trump card, the BJP, known for social engineering, has attempted to strike a balance in the government through Singh Deo, who is a member of the erstwhile royal family of Bolangir, and Parida, an OBC (Other Backward Class) politician.

THE NEW CM WILL HAVE TO HANDLE BABUS CAREFULLY, AFTER THE FREE REIN THEY HAD UNDER NAVEEN

Bhubaneswar-based political commentator Sandeep Mishra says the BJP has also looked at demography. "Majhi represents the tribal belt in north Odisha while Singh Deo comes from the western region, a BJP stronghold. With Parida, the party is recognising its growth in the coastal areas, known as a BJD bastion," says Mishra.

Singh Deo, like Majhi, is a veteran. He has been MLA from Patnagarh since 1995, narrowly losing the seat to the Biju Janata Dal only once in 2019. The former Odisha BJP president was a minister in the BJD-BJP alliance government in the state between 2000 and 2009. Parida is a first-time lawmaker from Nimapara, on the coast.

BJP sources describe Singh Deo, grandson of former CM

ANDHRA PRADESH

NAIDU 4.0

By Amarnath K. Menon



THE RULING COALITION The new CM and deputy CM felicitate the PM in Vijaywada, Jun. 12

ANI

Emotions pretty often get the better of Andhra Pradesh's new chief minister Chandrababu Naidu. So it was on June 12, when just before mid-day, and shortly after state governor Syed Abdul Nazeer administered the oath of office to him, Naidu presented Prime Minister Narendra Modi with a bouquet and a tight hug. That bonhomie at the ceremony, at the Kesarapalli Information Technology Park near Gannavaram airport, held before legions of enthusiastic supporters of Naidu's Telugu Desam Party, actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party and the Bharatiya Janata Party, signalled the launch of the new coalition government, the state's very first.

Naidu carried that spirit into his 24-member ministry as well, which boasts three ministers, including deputy CM Kalyan, from the JSP, and one from the BJP. Ten of these, including Kalyan and Naidu's son Nara Lokesh, No. 3 in the hierarchy, are first-time MLAs. Eight others, though familiar with electoral success, have debuted as ministers. Lokesh picked a majority of them, heeding region, gender and caste compulsions: three women, eight backwards, two Dalits and one Adivasi. Naidu went with his choices. Of the other castes, four each of the Kapu and Naidu's Kamma cohort, three Reddys and a Vysya come in. Seniors and heavyweights elected in the TDP's landslide triumph, which Naidu admits was unexpected, have been kept out. One berth stays vacant: Naidu wanted to accommodate two of the BJP's eight legislators, the party gave him only one name. The TDP has 135 and the JSP 21 MLAs, making for a truly grand total of 164 in the 175-seat assembly.

The deft balancing act accomplished, Naidu hopes the coalition government under the National Democratic Alliance banner will help him give the state a makeover. "Our goal and challenge is to rebuild Andhra Pradesh," he declared soon after being elected legislature party leader on June 11. This will be Naidu's fourth term, and he returns to a role he is familiar with, as well as issues of governance, especially in the face of depleted financial reserves. Still,